when I found a book to buy (Simon Winchester's essay collection, *Outposts*), he said, with some emotion: 'I will *not* let you pay for this.' When he insisted, I asked only that he inscribe the book for me.

When I went back the following day, Mr Shanbhag had regained his composure. I bought some books and paid for them, and he made me sign some copies of a book I had written. He had, he said, a week more to run, before he put down his shutters and put himself in the hands of the eye surgeon. By now, word of his closure had spread. Every day the number of visitors grew. The great mound in the middle of the shop became shorter and slimmer. The top layers on the side shelves were peeled off by paying customers, to reveal books published in the 1980s and before, that had lain buried, unseen and unsold.

On the first Sunday after Mr Shanbhag had made his decision known, a city magazine organized a photo shoot. Several writers were called to feature in the frame, among them the distinguished Kannada novelist U.R. Anantha Murthy. As he sat himself down among us, Anantha Murthy asked, 'Why is Girish [Karnad] not here?' I knew the answer: that great patron of Premier's could not come because his daughter was getting married the next week. I said that Girish's wife sometimes told him, when he came home with the day's loot, that their house had begun to resemble Shanbhag's shop, with books on the steps, books on the window sill, books on the kitchen counter, books everywhere including on one's head. I added that my wife sometimes told me the same thing. There were laughs all around, the loudest from Mr Shanbhag.

I went back several times the next week. Once I took my daughter along, so that she could buy her own last books from Premier's, and also take some photographs of the shop and its owner. It did not look at all like a store that was soon to go out of business. Customers bumped into one another on the narrow walkways. Some faces were known to me—I had seen them, and they, me, in the same place for the last twenty years, and more. But there were strangers too, as well as surprises. A lady peeked in